



United States Department of Agriculture

Research, Education, and Economics
Agricultural Research Service

THIS IS A PRE-SOLICITATION NOTICE. THIS IS NOT A REQUEST FOR QUOTES. The United States Department of Agriculture (USDA), Agriculture Research Service (ARS) is posting this pre-solicitation notice in accordance with FAR 5.101.

Point of Contact:

Frank Palmer, Contracting Officer

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The proposed contract action will be a total small business set aside. The North American Industry Classification System (NAICS) 336411 – Aircraft Manufacturing, which contains a size standard of 1,500 employees is applicable to this acquisition.

Description:

This requirement is for a Freefly Systems Astro Max (NDAA/Blue) Unmanned Aerial Vehicle or Equivalent.

Scope of Work:

This requirement is for the acquisition of an unmanned aerial vehicle for the collection of remotely sensed imagery data.

Technical Specifications Freefly Systems Astro Max (NDAA/Blue) Unmanned Aerial Vehicle or Equivalent:

- Astro Max (NDAA/Blue)
 - Up to 43 minutes flight time
 - 31 minutes with LR1 Payload
 - 20 minutes with max payload (3kg)
 - 3kg max payload
 - Booms fold up to ½ the diameter
 - Alternate payload attachments sold separately:
 - [Integrator Vibration Isolator](#) (non-electronic)
 - [Freefly Smart Dovetail Kit](#) (hard mount)
 - Standard Remote ID enabled - contact support with FAA waiver or other exemption to have it disabled
 - Optional LTE connectivity (North America only) [Learn more](#)
 - Additional specs in the [Astro wiki](#)
- Pilot Pro Controller
 - [Freefly Pro Pro controller](#)
 - High resolution rockers for precise camera / gimbal control
 - Configured with robust long-range radio hardware:
 - Doodle Labs RF, NDAA and DIU Blue (2.4 GHz)
 - Internal battery with external power inputs to support hot-swapping for maximum uptime
 - Emergency kill-switch

- Discreet physical buttons for all key user actions
- Includes custom configured, pre-installed 8" Samsung Galaxy Tab Active5 tablet
- Realtime drone and gimbal speed limits
- Custom padded neck strap
- [Astro Compact Travel Case](#)
 - Holds everything needed to fly Astro
 - Astro with 2 SL8 batteries* installed and legs folded
 - Pilot Pro radio controller
 - LR1 Payload (sold separately)
 - Pair of SL8 Chargers
 - Set of spare props (1 each CW & CCW)
 - Basic tools
 - Custom cut foam, tested to protect against drops from 1 meter
 - Submersible and dust tight (MIL-STD 810G)
 - Airline checkable
 - SKB Rolling Case - [3i-2217-10](#)
 - Case dimensions: 24.52" x 19.5" x 12.22" / 62.28 x 49.53 x 31.04 cm
 - Weight of Astro in case:
 - As shipped/checked (no SL8s): 36.16 lbs / 16.40 kg
 - Full kit (with two SL8s*): 40.66 lbs / 18.44 kg
- Batteries
 - [SL8-Air Batteries](#)*
 - Astro uses two SL8-Air batteries per flight
 - Voltage: 21.6 V (6S)
 - Capacity: 7.3 Ah, 157 Wh
 - Weight: 2.25lbs
 - Chemistry: Lithium-Ion
 - Auxiliary output: USB-C Power Delivery
- Chargers
 - [SL8 Fast Charger](#)*
 - One charger charges one Freefly SL8-Air battery at a time
 - Approximate charge time for one SL8-Air battery, from 0%: 90 mins
 - Input: 100 / 240 VAC
 - Output: 200 Watts
 - Supplied with North America power cable (NEMA 1-15 ungrounded, Type A).
 - Power cable is replaceable (IEC320 connector).

Quotes for this requirement will be solicited from at least three sources in accordance with FAR 12.201-1 (c) (2). This requirement will be awarded based on the lowest price technically acceptable. The anticipated award date is May 2026.

All responsible sources may submit a quotation which will be considered by the agency.

Vendors are required to be active and registered in the System for Award Management at www.sam.gov when submitting a quote and at time of award (FAR 52.204-7). Payment will be made utilizing the Department of the Treasury Invoice Processing Platform at www.ipp.gov. SAM.gov and IPP.gov are FREE, official websites of the United States government.

The Government reserves the right to reject, in whole or in part, any contractor's input resulting from this pre-solicitation notice. No contract will be awarded as a result of this notice. Data submitted in response to this pre-solicitation notice will not be returned. This request is for informational purposes only and the Government will not pay any costs associated with the preparation and submission of a response to this notice.

All interested contractors who can meet the requirements stated above should respond with information describing their interest, capabilities statements, and indicate the small business category for which they qualify. E-mail responses are required. The due date for responses to this pre-solicitation notice is at 11:00 am Mountain Daylight Time on Thursday, April 30, 2026. Please email your responses to frank.palmer@usda.gov.

Electronic files must be in Microsoft Office Word or PDF format. All information must be UNCLASSIFIED material.

Respondents should include as part of their submission:

- a. A synopsis of the company's capabilities to meet the requirements stated above (limit 5 pages).
- b. UEI Number.
- c. Company Name.
- d. Company Address.
- e. Business size as validated via the System for Award Administration (SAM). All offerors must register on the SAM located at <http://www.sam.gov>.
- f. Company points of contact, phone number, and email address.
- g. Past work experience. If you have experience working with other Federal Agencies and/or commercial businesses of similar size and scope, please include agency and/or business name contract number (if applicable), amount and type of contract.

Any company proprietary information must be marked as such.

THIS IS NOT A REQUEST FOR QUOTE. Interested firms are reminded that in accordance with FAR 4.12, prospective contractors must complete electronic annual representations and certifications and in conjunction with FAR 4.11, are required to be registered in the System for Award Management (SAM) at the time an offer or quotation is submitted.

[END OF PRE-SOLICITATION NOTICE]